

Project / Business Idea Name*

MediLink Rwanda

Sector of your Idea/Business*

Health

Problem Statement*

The idea for MediLink Rwanda came after observing long queues at local health centers like CHUK and hearing repeated complaints from working parents and elderly patients. It made us question why healthcare access still feels uncertain in a country that is rapidly digitizing other sectors.

In many health institutions, patients end up waiting for three to four hours before they are attended to by a doctor. For a working class, this means lost income. For parents, this means worrying about a sick child. For an elderly person living with a chronic condition, this is overwhelming.

During the survey we conducted in the Gasabo, Nyarugenge, and Kicukiro districts, several people shared that they often show up as early as 6 a.m. but are not attended to until the end of the afternoon. One elderly person said that, for them, the anxiety of the wait is sometimes more stressful than the sickness itself.

Through these conversations, we quickly realized that the problem is not that people are unaware of the information they need, but that they are not aware of access to information, such as whether a service is available, if they have insurance, and how long they need to wait.

Proposed Solution*

MediLink Rwanda is a mobile-based platform designed to make healthcare access more predictable and convenient. Instead of visiting a facility without knowing what to expect, patients can use a smartphone app, USSD, or WhatsApp to find verified public and private providers near their location.

Through the app, patients can confirm whether the facility accepts their insurance, such as Mutuelle, RAMA, or MMI, before traveling. Patients can see the availability of appointment

times, book appointments, and track the queue remotely to ensure that they arrive at the facility when they are near the front of the queue. In order to ensure that patients are not referred unnecessarily, we are developing a simple AI-powered symptom checker that will recommend the appropriate specialist for the patient.

For the healthcare providers, the app offers them the ability to manage appointments electronically, thereby reducing paperwork and no-shows.

The idea for the app was inspired by the feedback from the users, who complained about the lengthy waiting times. Our app is still in the development phase, focusing on the booking and queue system. We will generate revenue through affordable facility subscriptions and service charges.

What makes your idea unique or innovative?*

While some hospitals in Rwanda also have their own booking systems and telemedicine platforms offer remote consultations, these services operate independently. Patients still have to search facility by facility, often without knowing whether their insurance will be accepted.

MediLink Rwanda integrates these fragmented services into one place. The goal is simple: allow patients to check nearby public or private facilities, confirm insurance coverage such as Mutuelles, RAMA, or MMI, and see available appointments before leaving home.

The other notable difference is that of queue visibility. Instead of queuing for long periods without information, patients are able to track their position and plan when to arrive. In addition, we have ensured that the platform is accessible via USSD and WhatsApp to cater to those without smartphones, especially in rural areas.

To avoid unwarranted referrals, the platform has a simple symptom checker that provides a guideline of the kind of doctor a patient might need. This ensures that major referral hospitals are not overwhelmed and that the distribution of patients is rational. For the first time, patients are empowered to make informed decisions, and the healthcare system is used as it should be.

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Expected Impact*

MediLink Rwanda has been built to produce tangible, measurable results that create a significant, positive impact on the following three main areas:

Social Impact: We aim to reduce the average waiting time by 50% in the first year, especially in high-traffic district hospitals. This will ensure that patients receive faster healthcare services, hence improving patient satisfaction.

Economic Impact: Our main focus at MediLink Rwanda is to ensure that the 1.5 hours saved on average for every patient visiting the hospital for healthcare services can be recovered. In the case of hospitals, the management tools that MediLink Rwanda offers will ensure that the hospitals are not lose any revenue from patients who fail to turn up for appointments.

Systemic Impact: . If implemented effectively and adopted by both public and private facilities, the platform could significantly reduce pressure on major referral hospitals like CHUK by ensuring that patient flow to underutilized local facilities is increased by 30%

Through improved access efficiency, MediLink contributes to a better healthcare system and supports Rwanda's aspiration for a modern and technologically advanced health system.